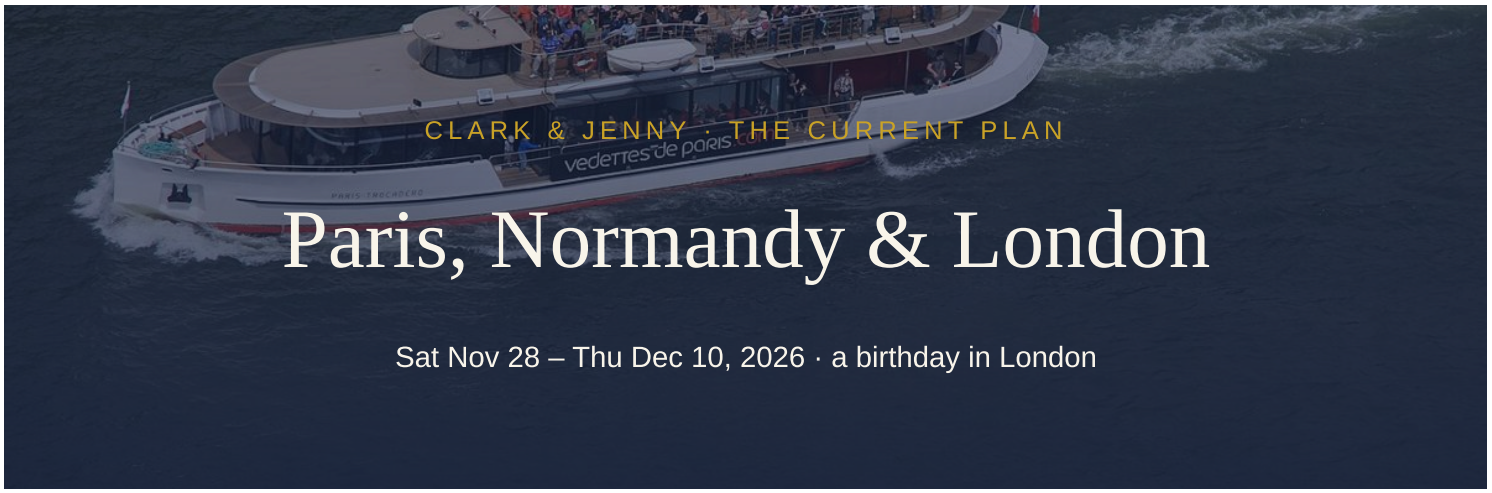


CLARK & JENNY · THE CURRENT PLAN

Paris, Normandy & London

Sat Nov 28 – Thu Dec 10, 2026 · a birthday in London

FLIGHTS BOOKED. HOTELS, TRAINS AND DINNERS FROM SAT DEC 5 ON ARE READY TO BOOK SOON, NOT BOOKED YET.

The Paris week is unchanged. Then five extra days: a night facing Mont-Saint-Michel, the D-Day coast and an evening ferry to a night in Portsmouth, and three nights in London with the birthday dinner on Mon Dec 7. Same rhythm: slow mornings, one light anchor a day, one proper dinner.

Weather: Normandy and London in December are cool, grey and damp, highs around 45–48 °F, windy on the coast; sunset ~4:55 PM in Normandy and ~3:50 PM in London. Pack layers, a waterproof jacket and good shoes.

Flights (booked, United Polaris via Chicago): Out Sat Nov 28: UA5867 Traverse City 2:18 PM → O'Hare 2:55 PM, then UA987 O'Hare 6:45 PM → Paris CDG 9:55 AM Nov 29. Home Thu Dec 10 (open-jaw from London Heathrow T2): UA928 1:35 PM → O'Hare 4:55 PM (seats 4D/5F), then UA2304 O'Hare 7:45 PM → Traverse City 9:59 PM (First, 2E/2F).

DAY 0

Sat Nov 28 · Travel day

Anchor: Get to Paris rested.



Morning	Pack, and a relaxed early afternoon departure from home.
Afternoon	**UA5867** 2:18 PM → O'Hare 2:55 PM (seats 2C/2D), short hop from Traverse City (TVC) to Chicago O'Hare on United. Time in the United Polaris lounge: sit-down dinner, shower suite, quiet room.
Evening	Overnight United Polaris flight Chicago → Paris CDG. Dinner was in the lounge, so sleep early. **UA987** O'Hare 6:45 PM → Paris CDG 9:55 AM Sun Nov 29 (seats 3D/3F).

DAY 1

Sun Nov 29 · Arrive and settle

Anchor: None. Land, rest, tub.



Morning	Land at CDG Terminal 1 mid-morning. Pre-booked car to the hotel (hotel car or Welcome Pickups). Drop bags at Hôtel Le Cinq Codet around noon.
Afternoon	Latte at Noir – Rue de Grenelle, pastry from La Parisienne. Check in at 3 PM, nap and the tub. Optional wander down Rue Cler.
Evening	Dusk walk to the Champ de Mars (sunset ~4:57 PM; the Tower sparkles on the hour). 7:30 PM dinner at Bistrot des Fables. Jenny: salmon with sorrel or sea bream. Dessert: bourbon-vanilla crème brûlée.

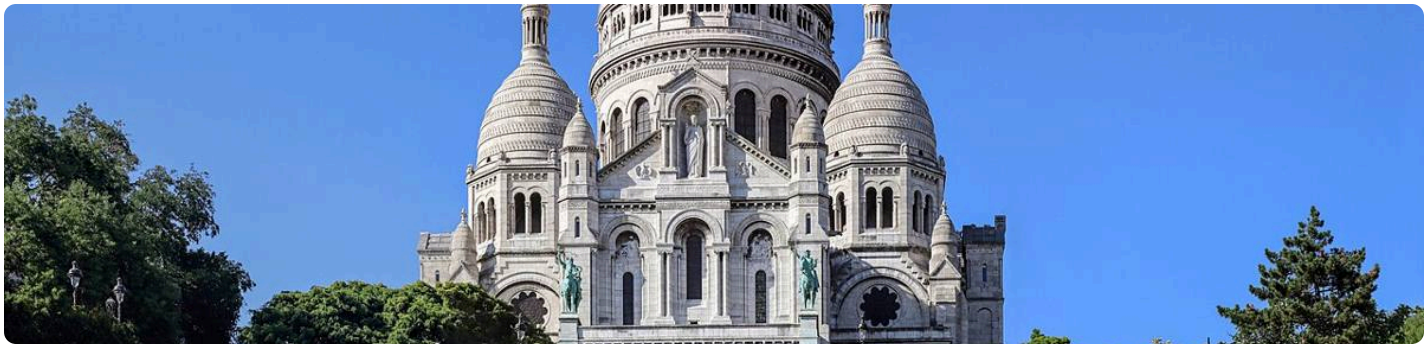
DAY 2

Mon Nov 30 · Montmartre at sunset + Moulin Rouge

Anchor: One evening outing.



Morning	Late start. Latte at Dialogues Coffee, then tub and rest.
Afternoon	1 PM lunch at Les Cocottes (Jenny: roast cod). ~3:15 taxi to Montmartre; dress smart for tonight. Ride the funicular up to Sacré-Cœur.
Evening	Sunset from the basilica steps (~4:56 PM), stroll Place du Tertre. **Moulin Rouge Dinner & Show**: doors 6:45, dinner with the orchestra at 7 PM, Féerie show at 9 PM. Jenny: the **Belle Époque menu** (smoked salmon, then pike-perch) — flag the shellfish allergy when booking. Smart dress, no trainers. Taxi home ~11 PM. Book only via reservations.moulinrouge.fr.



Sacré-Cœur, Montmartre

DAY 3

Tue Dec 1 · Catacombs + lunch at Baguette

Anchor: The Catacombs, then a long lunch.



Morning	~9:15 filter coffee at Coutume. Metro line 6 to Denfert-Rochereau. 10:30 timed entry at the Catacombes de Paris (~1 hr, 131 steps down / 112 up, ~14 °C inside — bring a layer, no big bags).
Afternoon	Taxi to Montorgueil. 12:15 lunch at Baguette, French-Asian small plates. Jenny: salmon tartare with ginger, truffle risotto, smoked aubergine — skip the shrimp spring roll. Dessert: black-sesame crème brûlée. Keep it light. Taxi back, rest and tub.
Evening	7:30 PM dinner at Café Caillou. Jenny: fresh salmon, mushroom risotto or aubergine gratin. Clark: a Chinon by the bottle.



The Montorgueil quarter, home of Baguette

DAY 4

Wed Dec 2 · Versailles + Gordon Ramsay au Trianon

Anchor: The palace, then the starred dinner. Long day; taxi home.



Morning	~9:15 pastry; dress smart casual for dinner. ~9:45 RER C from Champ de Mars–Tour Eiffel to Versailles Château Rive Gauche (~35–40 min). 11:00 timed entry, Palace of Versailles (Passport ticket).
Afternoon	~1 PM lunch at Ore – Ducasse in the palace grounds. Jenny: truite aux amandes; skip the raw scallops. ~2:30 gardens, then the Trianons and Marie-Antoinette's Hamlet (last entry 4:45).
Evening	~5 PM drinks at the Waldorf Astoria Trianon Palace bar: an Old Fashioned for Clark, Crémant for Jenny. 7:30 PM Gordon Ramsay au Trianon ★ — request a pescatarian, shellfish-free menu at booking (signatures use lobster and cockles). ~10:15 pre-booked taxi back to the hotel: **the RER C closes evenings from 11 PM for works**.



Trianon Palace, home of Gordon Ramsay au Trianon

DAY 5

Thu Dec 3 · The big-view day

Anchor: The 5 PM Seine cruise.



Morning	~10:00 slow coffee at Dialogues. Optional walk over Pont d'Iéna to the Trocadéro esplanade for the classic Tower view.
Afternoon	1 PM light lunch at Les Cocottes. Tub and rest. Leave 4:35, dressed warm.
Evening	5 PM cruise with Bateaux Parisiens (Port de la Bourdonnais), back ~6 PM as the Tower sparkles. Old Fashioned at Minuit Express. ~7:45 dinner at Le Bosquet (Jenny: grilled cod, sauce vierge — oysters on the menu, flag the allergy).

DAY 6

Fri Dec 4 · Super-relaxed last day

Anchor: None. Early night.



Morning	Late breakfast from La Parisienne, latte at Noir, last stroll down Rue Cler.
Afternoon	Light lunch at Les Cocottes. Hotel spa and a long soak. Pack; confirm the morning car.
Evening	7 PM farewell dinner at La Fontaine de Mars. Jenny: salmon in salt crust or roasted sea bass. Dessert: crème brûlée à la vanille. Lights out ~10.

DAY 7 **READY TO BOOK**

Sat Dec 5 · Paris → Mont-Saint-Michel

Anchor: Arrive at the Mont by sunset.



Morning	Slow breakfast and check out of Le Cinq Codet (~10:00). Taxi to Paris-Montparnasse. **TGV INOUI 8615** Montparnasse 10:57 AM → Rennes 12:25 PM, direct (SNCF Connect timetable; times from the current timetable, confirm when December sales open). Earlier backup: TGV 8609, 10:00 → 11:25.
Afternoon	Lunch at Rennes station, then pick up a premium sedan or SUV at SIXT Rennes station (one-way, returned in Caen on Sunday). Easy, toll-free drive to the Mont (~1 hr 15), arriving ~2:45 PM. No-car fallback: the Keolis Rennes → Mont-Saint-Michel bus, timed to the Paris TGVs. Check in at Le Relais Saint-Michel (Signature room, facing the Mont).
Evening	Sunset (~4:55 PM) from the hotel terrace, then the free shuttle across and a quiet walk up the lit, empty village. Dinner at the Relais Saint-Michel restaurant facing the lit Mont (open nightly 7–9:30 PM). Jenny: local fish of the day; Normandy is shellfish country, so flag the allergy every time.

DAY 8 **READY TO BOOK**

Sun Dec 6 · Abbey, D-Day coast, then the evening ferry

Anchor: Abbey at opening, the American Cemetery, and the 4:30 PM sailing to England.



Morning	Breakfast with the view. 9:30 AM opening at the Mont-Saint-Michel Abbey (~45 min; dress warm). Check out and leave the Mont at ~10:30.
Afternoon	Drive ~1 hr 50 on the A84 to the Normandy American Cemetery above Omaha Beach; picnic or café lunch, about 1 hr 15 there (~12:15–1:30). Drive ~50 min to Caen station and drop the car by ~2:30 (confirm Sunday key drop with SIXT), then a 20-min taxi to the Ouistreham ferry port, arriving ~3:00. Foot-passenger check-in closes at 3:30.
Evening	**Brittany Ferries** Caen-Ouistreham 4:30 PM → Portsmouth 9:30 PM UK time (~6 hrs; the 4:30 sailing runs every day of the year). Book a cabin to nap, plus dinner on board (Jenny: fish, flag the shellfish allergy). Disembarking takes ~30 min, then a 5–10 min taxi to the Royal Maritime Hotel (Queen Street, by the Historic Dockyard; staffed desk, check-in until 1 AM, so a ~10 PM arrival is fine). Straight to bed.

DAY 9 **READY TO BOOK**

Mon Dec 7 · Birthday · Portsmouth → London

Anchor: A slow morning and lunchtime arrival in London, then the birthday dinner.



Morning	Sleep in. Breakfast at the hotel, then a stroll by the harbour (HMS Victory and the Spinnaker Tower are a short stroll). **South Western Railway** direct train Portsmouth Harbour 10:55 AM → London Waterloo 1:04 PM (2h09; weekday pattern; trains run about every 30 min if you want to linger).
Afternoon	Taxi from Waterloo to The London EDITION in Fitzrovia (~20 min), arriving ~1:30 PM. Superior King on the flexible Stay Longer on Us rate; birthday noted and an upgrade requested. Check-in is 3 PM, so lunch in Fitzrovia or drop bags and nap. Time to dress for dinner.
Evening	Birthday dinner, ~8 PM. Top pick: Core by Clare Smyth in Notting Hill (~20 min by taxi; request a pescatarian, shellfish-free menu at booking). Alternatives: Hélène Darroze at The Connaught (3 stars, Mayfair, ~10 min by taxi) or Berners Tavern in the hotel (no taxi at all). Old Fashioned first in the hotel Punch Room; Champagne or English sparkling for Jenny; crème brûlée if it is on.

DAY 10 **READY TO BOOK**

Tue Dec 8 · Churchill War Rooms + Christmas at Kew

Anchor: A morning museum, then the lights at Kew.



Morning	Slow morning. ~11 AM timed entry to the Churchill War Rooms (~1 hr 30; taxi ~15 min). Alternative: the Tower of London and the Crown Jewels. The Bayeux Tapestry at the British Museum (a 10-min walk from the hotel) is sold out; worth checking for returns.
Afternoon	Lunch near Westminster, then back to the hotel to rest.
Evening	Taxi (~45 min) to Christmas at Kew for an early-evening timed entry, the illuminated trail through the gardens (~1 hr 30, dress warm). Taxi back and a relaxed late dinner.

DAY 11 **READY TO BOOK**

Wed Dec 9 · London at Christmas

Anchor: Winter Wonderland at dusk.



Morning	Late breakfast. Wander Soho and Covent Garden (both walkable from the hotel).
Afternoon	Afternoon tea or a long lunch. Rest and pack.
Evening	Stroll into Hyde Park Winter Wonderland after dark (open Nov 19 – Jan 3). Farewell dinner; early night.

DAY 12 **FLIGHTS BOOKED**

Thu Dec 10 · Fly home from Heathrow

Anchor: A relaxed last morning, then Polaris home.



Morning	Late breakfast and a slow pack. Leave the hotel at ~10:15 AM: 5-min walk to Tottenham Court Road and the Elizabeth line direct to Heathrow Terminals 2 & 3 (~35 min), arriving ~11:00 for the 1:35 PM flight. With bags, a taxi (~1 hr) is the easy alternative.
Afternoon	**UA928** Heathrow T2 1:35 PM → Chicago O'Hare 4:55 PM, United Polaris (Boeing 767-300). Seats: Clark 4D, Jenny 5F (center seats, one diagonally behind the other).
Evening	2h50 connection at O'Hare: clear passport control and customs, re-check bags and re-screen, then a sit-down dinner in the United Polaris lounge (Terminal 1, near gate C18). **UA2304** O'Hare 7:45 PM → Traverse City 9:59 PM, First, seats 2E/2F.

READY TO BOOK

Open items

Item	What
Hotels to book (top pick, then alternatives)	Mont-Saint-Michel Dec 5: Le Relais Saint-Michel (open all year, rooms and restaurant facing the Mont; ask for a Mont-view room). Alternatives: La Mère Poulard (historic inn inside the walls, open all year) or Les Terrasses Poulard / La Confiance (in the village; many steps with bags). Avoid Hôtel Gabriel and Relais du Roy: closed in winter. Portsmouth Dec 6: Royal Maritime Hotel (historic naval club hotel, indoor pool, ~8 min walk to Portsmouth Harbour station; check-in until 1 AM). Alternatives: Holiday Inn Express Gunwharf Quays (modern, breakfast included, 3 min to the station) or The Ship Leopard (boutique, opposite the station; some street noise). London Dec 7–10: The London EDITION, 10 Berners St, Fitzrovia, Superior King on the flexible Stay Longer on Us rate (birthday noted, upgrade requested).

Rental car	Premium sedan or SUV, Rennes station Sat Dec 5 → Caen station Sun Dec 6, mid-afternoon drop (one-way, same country).
Trains and ferry	Dec 5: TGV 8615 Paris-Montparnasse 10:57 AM → Rennes 12:25 PM. Dec 6: Brittany Ferries Caen-Ouistreham 4:30 PM → Portsmouth 9:30 PM (foot passengers, cabin). Dec 7: SWR Portsmouth Harbour 10:55 AM → London Waterloo 1:04 PM. All ready to book; no Paris routing.
Birthday dinner	Core by Clare Smyth (top pick), Hélène Darroze at The Connaught, or Berners Tavern, Mon Dec 7 ~8 PM — pescatarian, no shellfish.
London sights	Churchill War Rooms or Tower of London, plus Christmas at Kew, Tue Dec 8. Bayeux Tapestry at the British Museum is sold out (check for returns).

Dining notes

Jenny: pescatarian, shellfish allergy

> **Je suis allergique aux fruits de mer et crustacés. Je mange du poisson mais pas de fruits de mer.**
> *In London: "Pescatarian, with a shellfish allergy — no prawns, crab, lobster, scallops, mussels or oysters, and no shellfish stock."*

Normandy menus lean on oysters, mussels and scallops; ask for the fish of the day (sole, bar, cabillaud, saumon). Jenny: Crémant or Champagne in France, English sparkling in London. Clark: bold reds, an Old Fashioned in the hotel bar, crème brûlée when it appears.

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